

ing of the lot, but we can't be mad at him because he's really - and I mean really - cool. Even the villains are written very well; you will even find yourself rooting for them at times. The game does an excellent job of presenting a multifaceted narrative, allowing players to see the story unfold from different character perspectives, adding layers of depth and intrigue. Also, probably the best Cid ever.

It's not just Clive though, all the prominent characters are well-written and undergo significant development throughout the game. Each protagonist and antagonist has their own motivations, and the interactions between them are rich with emotions, dilemmas, and personal struggles.

The game does not shy away from exploring complex themes, such as sacrifice, redemption, and the consequences of one's actions. Also, for a Final Fantasy game, FFXVI features surprisingly mature themes, things we really wouldn't expect to see in a Final Fantasy game, and it's honestly quite refreshing. Guess the franchise is finally growing up with us. We'll avoid delving into the story to avoid spoilers but we will say that the overarching plot is great. We found the pacing to be both slow and extremely fast at times, which gets a bit confusing if you're earnestly following the plot.

Gameplay

Final Fantasy XVI introduces a refreshing twist to the series' traditional turn-based combat and instead introduces a real-time combat system that breathes new life into the gameplay. It's fluid, and responsive, and when you figure it out, a blast to pull off. Players can seamlessly transition from evasive maneuvers to powerful attacks. Active Time Battle or ATB still exists, but has been seamlessly integrated into real-time combat in the form of powerful abilities that you



need to think about before using, adding an element of strategy into the fray. These powerful Eikonic abilities can also combo with each other surprisingly well if you take the time to experiment and figure them out. Eikons, which fans of the franchise may know as summons, play a significant role in combat. Clive has access to several of them at any given time, with each allowing Clive to mix and match different abilities (those combos that we just spoke of above). Clive also has the ability to turn into an Eikon himself! That's all we'll say here to avoid spoilers. We will say it does look friggin' awesome though.

Now, for long-time players of the franchise who are accustomed to turn-based combat, the faster paced real-time combat can be a bit overwhelming. However, with a bit of practice and understanding of the mechanics, players will likely find the combat system to be immensely satisfying.

Graphics and Audio

Final Fantasy XVI looks gorgeous. The game features highly detailed character models, stunning visual effects, and impressive animations. The developers

have spared no expense in creating a visually stunning world. The game takes full advantage of the PS5's capabilities.

Complementing the exceptional graphics is the game's captivating soundtrack. Final Fantasy XVI's music, composed by industry veteran Nobuo Uematsu, creates a magical atmosphere that further draws players into the world. The orchestral

score perfectly captures the emotions and themes of the game, heightening the impact of pivotal moments. Each track is carefully crafted to match the tone and setting of the scenes, enhancing the player's emotional connection to the narrative. The voice acting in Final Fantasy XVI is also top-notch and a big part of what makes the characters so interesting.

Valisthea, the setting of Final Fantasy XVI, is also beautifully crafted, with lush environments, diverse landscapes, and vibrant cities that bring the world to life. The cities and towns of Valisthea are bustling with life and culture, featuring unique architectural styles and distinct cultural elements. These elements combine to create a living, breathing world that feels immersive and inviting. The game encourages exploration, rewarding players with hidden treasures, side quests, and lore-rich locations. Exploring the vast landscapes of Valisthea feels rewarding, as players stumble upon breathtaking vistas, ancient ruins, and hidden caves. The seamless transition between exploration and combat adds to the overall immersive experience.

Verdict

Final Fantasy is back babe! FFXVI delivers a gaming experience that will satisfy both long-time fans and newcomers alike. The new combat system is fantastic, the overall story is compelling and keeps you going, and the world building is captivating. All of which combined makes for countless hours of enjoyment. While the occasional pacing issues may hinder the storytelling experience, the character development more than compensates for this. With its breathtaking graphics and soundtrack, and seamless integration of gameplay mechanics, Final Fantasy XVI cements itself as a standout title in the RPG genre. Square Enix's latest installment is an ambitious and successful addition to the beloved franchise, setting a high standard for future Final Fantasy's and RPGs to follow. If you're a fan of epic adventures and gripping stories, Final Fantasy XVI is a must-play list. *

MOAR!

PUBLISHER
Square Enix

DEVELOPER
Square Enix
(Creative Business Unit III)

PLATFORM
PlayStation 5

PRICE
₹4,799